



THE FAST TRACK TO

BIBLE HISTORY

LESLI D. MIZE



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THE FAST TRACK TO BIBLE HISTORY

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A Clear & Approachable Guide to How the Bible Came to Us

Lesli D. Mize

BalancingtheWordMinistry

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This study guide is intended for educational and devotional purposes and reflects widely accepted historical scholarship presented from a Christian perspective.



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Colossians 1:28

Balancing the Word Ministry exists to teach, train, and equip believers through Scripture, historical context, and biblical discernment—grounded in truth and centered on Christ.

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“Him we proclaim, warning everyone and teaching everyone with all wisdom, that we may present everyone mature in Christ.” — Colossians 1:28

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Introduction:

Welcome to the Fast Track to Bible History

If you've ever opened the Bible and wondered where to begin, you're not alone.

For many people, the Bible can feel overwhelming at first glance—sixty-six books, written across centuries, filled with history, poetry, law, prophecy, letters, and stories that span cultures and continents. It's easy to assume that understanding the Bible requires advanced training or years of study.

But that was never God's intention.

The Fast Track to Bible History was created to help you step back, take a deep breath, and see the Bible as it truly is, a unified, carefully preserved story of God's work in the world—and His desire to be known by His people.

Throughout this study, we'll explore questions like:

- What is the Bible, really?
- How was God's Word shared before it was written?
- How do we know Scripture was preserved accurately?
- Why are translations important?
- What role does the Torah play in the story of redemption?

Think of it as a guided walk through the big ideas of Bible history—meant to build confidence, spark curiosity, and encourage deeper reading. Each lesson is written in a straightforward, conversational way, with fun, reflective worksheets to help reinforce what you're learning—without feeling like homework.

You're invited to read, reflect, and engage at your own pace. Most importantly, this guide is meant to remind you of something essential: God has always been intentional about revealing Himself. He spoke, His Word was remembered, it was written, it was preserved, it was translated, and today, it is placed in your hands.

Whether you're new to studying Scripture or simply looking for a refreshing overview, my prayer is that this guide strengthens your confidence in God's Word and encourages you to keep exploring it with clarity and joy.

So, let's begin!

Lesli D. Mize
Balancing the Word Ministry

Lesson 1: Basic Bible Facts

What Is the Bible—and Why Does Its History Matter?



PART I

Before we talk about what the Bible says, it helps to understand what the Bible actually is.

Many people think of the Bible as a single book that dropped out of the sky fully formed. In reality, the Bible is more like a library—a carefully preserved collection of writings brought together over time, telling one unified story.

The Bible is made up of 66 books, written by more than 40 authors, over a span of roughly 1,500 years. These books include history, poetry, wisdom literature, prophecy, letters, and eyewitness accounts. And yet—despite being written across different centuries, cultures, and circumstances—the Bible speaks with one consistent message.

Christians believe the Bible is not merely human writing, but God-breathed Scripture, inspired by God and given to guide, teach, correct, and train His people (*2 Timothy 3:16–17*).

The Bible is divided into two main sections:

The Old Testament (**39 books**)

The New Testament (**27 books**)



Two Testaments—One Story

The Old Testament was written before the birth of Jesus Christ. It lays the foundation—introducing creation, humanity’s fall into sin, God’s covenant with Israel, and the promise of a coming Savior.

The New Testament reveals the fulfillment of that promise in Jesus Christ—through His life, death, and resurrection, and in the establishment of the early Church, where God’s redemptive plan is made visible to the world.

Together, the Old and New Testaments tell one continuous story:

God creating, humanity falling, and God redeeming His people through Jesus.

The Languages of the Bible

Another surprising fact about the Bible is that it was not written in English—or even in just one language. **Hebrew** was used for most of the Old Testament, **Aramaic** appears in parts of Ezra and Daniel, and **Greek** was used for the entire New Testament

These were the *common, everyday languages* of the people at the time. God chose languages people actually spoke, not elite or mysterious ones. From the very beginning, Scripture was meant to be understood, shared, and lived out.

*This is why translation has always mattered
and why the Bible is available in our own language today.*



Part II

How the Old Testament Came Together

The Old Testament was written between approximately **1400** and **400 B.C.** Jewish scribes, with extraordinary care, preserved these writings. Every letter, word, and line was copied with precision, because Scripture was considered sacred.

The Old Testament includes:

—**The Law (Torah)**-First five books-Genesis to Deuteronomy

Also known as the Pentateuch (Greek), which possesses the “Origin Stories” and the Laws for Israel written by Moses.

—**History (12 Books)**-Joshua to Esther

The “Adventure Stories” of Israel’s journey and settlement in the Promised Land, their wars and battles, and their kings

—**Poetry and Wisdom (5 Books)**-Job to Song of Solomon

The “Songbook and Advice” sections focused on emotions, worship, and wisdom for daily life.

—**The Major Prophets (5 Books)**-Isaiah to Daniel

The “Big Picture” of the warning and promises for God

—**The Minor Prophets (12 Books)**-Hosea to Malachi

“Messengers” who expanded the messages of the Major Prophets

By the time of Jesus, these Scriptures were already recognized as authoritative, with Jesus Himself quoting from them and affirming them as the Word of God.

How the New Testament Came Together

The New Testament was written between **A.D. 40** and **100**, primarily by the apostles of Jesus or by close associates who recorded eyewitness testimony. These writings were circulated widely among early churches, read publicly in worship, and copied and shared across regions.

The New Testament includes:

—The Gospels (4 Books)-Matthew to John

“Eyewitness Accounts” of Jesus’ life, death, and resurrection.

—History (1 Book)-Acts

The “Launch” of the early church

—Pauline Epistles (13 Books)-Romans to Philemon

Apostle Paul’s letters were directed to the early churches for encouragement and correction.

—General Epistles (8 Books)-Hebrews to Jude

Letters written by other authors, such as Peter and James, to the broader community of believers.

—Prophecy (1 Book)-Revelation

The “Vision” of the end of the age and the new beginning.

The early church did not randomly choose books; instead, the writings were recognized as Scripture based on clear standards: apostolic authorship, consistency with the teachings of Jesus, widespread acceptance by believers, and evidence of spiritual authority.



Part III

What Does “Canon” Mean?

The word canon simply means rule or measuring rod. It refers to the standard by which Scripture was recognized—not invented. Around A.D. 90, Jewish leaders recognized the Old Testament canon. In **A.D. 397**, the Council of Carthage affirmed the 27 books of the New Testament. These councils did not create Scripture; they acknowledged what believers already recognized as God’s Word.

Ancient Manuscripts: Why They Matter

One of the strongest reasons the Bible is trusted is the overwhelming manuscript evidence. Some of the most important discoveries include: The Dead Sea Scrolls (dating from **200 B.C. to A.D. 100**), The Septuagint (**LXX**, which means “**70**,” referring to the group of Jewish scholars who translated the Hebrew Scriptures into Greek), a Greek translation of the Old Testament, the Codex Sinaiticus, and the Codex Vaticanus, early complete manuscripts. These manuscripts confirm that the Bible we read today faithfully reflects the original writings.



Part IV

From Scrolls to Translations

As Christianity spread, the Bible was translated into many languages so people everywhere could read it.

Key translations include:

—**Latin Vulgate — A.D. 405**

Completed by Jerome; became the official Bible of the Western Church for centuries.

—**Wycliffe’s Bible — 1382**

First complete Bible translated into Middle English (hand-copied manuscripts).

—**Tyndale Bible — 1526**

First printed English New Testament translated directly from Greek.

—**King James Version — 1611**

Commissioned by King James I; became the most influential English Bible.

Modern translations like NIV, ESV, CSB, NASB, and NLT exist not to confuse readers—but to help them understand Scripture more clearly.



PART V

Why the Bible Can Be Trusted

When people ask whether the Bible can really be trusted, it’s a fair question. After all, it’s an ancient book—or rather, a collection of ancient books. But this is where the Bible truly stands apart from every other historical writing.

To begin with, the New Testament is supported by over **25,000** ancient manuscripts. That level of evidence is unmatched in the ancient world. Most historical documents we accept without hesitation are supported by only a handful of copies—sometimes fewer than ten. By comparison, the Bible’s manuscript evidence is overwhelming.

Then there’s **prophecy**. The Bible contains predictions written hundreds of years before the events they describe—many of them fulfilled in precise and remarkable ways. These prophecies aren’t vague guesses or lucky coincidences; they unfold across centuries and converge with stunning consistency.

Archaeology adds another layer of confidence. Time and again, archaeological discoveries have confirmed people, places, and events recorded in Scripture. While archaeology doesn’t “prove” faith, it repeatedly shows that the Bible is rooted in real history, real locations, and real cultures.

Perhaps most striking of all is the Bible’s **unity**. Despite being written by dozens of authors, in different places, over many centuries, every book ultimately points to the same central figure—Jesus Christ. From Genesis to Revelation, the story moves toward redemption through Him.

The Bible’s Big Message

At its core, the Bible tells one grand story:

- Creation
- Fall
- Redemption
- Jesus Christ
- Salvation
- Eternal Life
- Restoration

From beginning to end, Scripture reveals who God is and what He has done to redeem humanity.



PART VI

Why the Bible Still Matters Today

The Bible isn’t just a collection of ancient writings preserved on fragile pages. It is a living Word—one that continues to speak with relevance, clarity, and purpose today.

Through its pages, the Bible offers guidance and hope, especially in seasons of uncertainty. It reveals the character of God—His faithfulness, justice, mercy, and love. It teaches us how to live wisely, helping us navigate relationships, decisions, and daily life with discernment.

Most importantly, the Bible points us to Jesus Christ. From beginning to end, Scripture reveals God's plan of salvation and invites every reader into a restored relationship with Him.

And this is only the beginning.



Coming Up Next...

In the next lesson, we'll slow down and explore how the Bible's story unfolds across history, helping you see Scripture not as scattered books—but as one beautifully connected narrative.

Please take a few moments to reflect on what you've just read before continuing to the worksheet that follows.

Worksheet: Lesson 1

Basic Bible Facts

Part 1: Bible Basics Warm-Up

1. The Bible is best described as:

- ☐ A single book written all at once
- ☐ A collection of 66 books written over time
- ☐ A history textbook
- ☐ A mystery novel

2. Circle the TWO main sections of the Bible:

Old Testament New Testament Apocrypha Gospels

Part 2: What's Inside the Bible?

Match the type of writing with what it includes:

History

Poetry

Letters

Prophecy

Songs & Prayers

Events & People

Instruction to churches

Messages from God

Part 3: Languages of the Bible

Fill in the blanks:

-Most of the Old Testament was written in _____.

-Parts of Ezra and Daniel were written in _____.

-The New Testament was written in _____.

Why do you think God chose everyday languages instead of one “holy” language?

Part 4: How Did We Get the Bible?

True or False:

1. The Bible was randomly put together.

True / False

2. The Old Testament was carefully preserved by scribes.

True / False

3.The New Testament books were recognized because they were popular.
True / False

4.The word “canon” means measuring rod or standard.
True / False

Part 5: Why Can the Bible Be Trusted?

Check all that apply:

- ☐ Thousands of ancient manuscripts
- ☐ Fulfilled prophecy
- ☐ Archaeological discoveries
- ☐ A unified message centered on Jesus
- ☐ Guesswork and legend

Part 6: The Big Story of the Bible

Number these in the correct order:

- ☐ Redemption
- ☐ Creation
- ☐ Jesus Christ
- ☐ Fall
- ☐ Eternal Life
- ☐ Restoration
- ☐ Salvation

Circle the center of the Bible’s story:

Creation Jesus Christ The Law The Church

(Hint: Every part of the Bible ultimately points to one Person.)

Part 7: Personal Reflection

1. What surprised you most about the Bible’s history?
2. What makes the Bible feel more approachable now?
3. What part of the Bible are you most curious to learn more about?

Bonus Question:

If the Bible were a library, which section would you visit most—and why?

Lesson 2: Oral Tradition

Transition: From Preserved Scrolls to Living Voices

The Dead Sea Scrolls showed us just how carefully God preserved His Word in written form. But long before Scripture was ever hidden in caves or copied onto scrolls, it lived first in spoken words—taught, remembered, and passed faithfully from one generation to the next.

To truly appreciate how God preserved His Word in writing, we need to step back even further and see how He first entrusted it to people’s voices, memories, and hearts. This lesson takes us to the very beginning—before ink, before parchment—to explore how God’s Word moved from oral tradition to written Scripture.

How God’s Word Was Shared Before It Was Ever Written

When we open the Bible today, it’s easy to forget how long God’s Word existed before ink ever touched parchment. Long before Scripture was written on scrolls or bound into books, it was spoken aloud. It was heard, remembered, repeated, and carefully passed from one generation to the next.

God did not rush this process. Instead, He guided His revelation patiently and intentionally, ensuring that His truth would endure—not just for a single moment in history, but for all who would come after.

Scripture Began as Spoken Word

In the ancient world, oral tradition was not casual storytelling; it was a **disciplined and trusted** way of preserving truth. Communities trained their memory carefully, sacred teachings were repeated often, corrected when needed, and guarded by priests, elders, and families.

God instructed His people not only to remember His words, but to **teach them diligently**—at home, along the road, and from one generation to the next (*Deuteronomy 6:6-7*). His Word was meant to live in the hearts and voices of His people, not merely on a page.

Through repetition and shared responsibility, God’s truth was protected, remembered, and lived out long before it was ever written down.

When God’s Word Began to Be Written

God’s Word was first spoken, remembered, and taught for generations. Yet at the right moment in history, God gave a new instruction:

“Moses wrote down their starting places, stage by stage, by command of the LORD.” (Numbers 33:2)

This marked an important shift—from spoken instruction to written record. What God had faithfully preserved through memory and teaching would now also be safeguarded in writing. God was not changing His method—He was strengthening it, ensuring His Word would endure as His people grew and spread.

The Beginning of Written Scripture

Around 1400–1200 B.C., God clearly instructed Moses to write His words down. The Law and covenant commands were recorded on tablets and scrolls, preserving what God had already spoken.

Writing did not replace oral teaching—it reinforced it. What had been spoken aloud was now also preserved in written form, ensuring accuracy, clarity, and continuity across generations. Once again, God provided exactly what His people needed at the right time in history.

Growth Through Israel's History

As Israel's story unfolded, Scripture continued to grow. Scribes recorded national events. Prophets wrote down messages God gave them for His people. Psalms that were first sung aloud were eventually gathered and preserved. Wisdom literature took shape through reflection, teaching, and lived experience.

Writing allowed God's Word to remain unified and accessible, even as generations passed and circumstances changed. What began as spoken instruction became a carefully preserved testimony of God's faithfulness across time.

Exile and the Urgency of Preservation

During the Babylonian exile, preserving Scripture became especially urgent. Israel had lost its land, its temple, and much of its national identity—but God's Word remained.

In this season of loss and uncertainty, scribes worked diligently to collect, preserve, and safeguard sacred writings. Scripture became the anchor of Israel's faith and identity. What exile could not destroy was the truth God had spoken.

Rather than fading away, God's Word was guarded more carefully than ever.



From Jesus' Teaching to the New Testament

When Jesus came, He taught primarily through spoken word. He told parables, taught crowds, and instructed His disciples face-to-face. After His resurrection, the apostles preached the gospel widely before any New Testament books were written.

Letters were written first to guide and encourage churches. Later, the Gospels were written to preserve eyewitness testimony of Jesus' life, death, and resurrection. Once again, God moved from spoken word to written Scripture—ensuring that the message of Christ would reach believers across time and place.

Why This Matters Today

The journey from oral tradition to written Scripture reveals something deeply reassuring: **God has always been intentional about preserving His Word.**

The Bible was not created suddenly or carelessly. It was spoken, taught, written, preserved, and passed down with purpose so that believers in every generation—including ours—could know God's truth.

When we open the Bible today, we are holding the result of God's patient and faithful care—a Word that was spoken long ago, written at the right time, and preserved so it would never be lost.



For generations, God's Word was carefully spoken, remembered, and passed down with intention. But as these sacred words moved from memory to manuscript, an important question naturally arises: How do we know what was written remained faithful to what was spoken? In the next lesson, we'll step into the discovery of the Dead Sea Scrolls—one of the most remarkable finds in history—which offers powerful evidence of how carefully God's Word was preserved over time.

****Before you move on, take a few moments to reflect on what you've just read in the worksheet that follows.**

Worksheet: Lesson 2

Oral Traditions

Part 1: Let's Think Back

1. Before this lesson, had you ever thought about how God's Word existed before it was written down?

- ☐ Not really
- ☐ A little
- ☐ Yes, but this gave me new insight

Part 2: Spoken Before Written

2. In your own words, explain what oral tradition means.

3. Why do you think oral tradition worked so well in ancient cultures? (Check all that apply)

- ☐ People trained their memory carefully
- ☐ Teaching happened within families and communities
- ☐ Sacred teachings were repeated often
- ☐ God designed it that way
- ☐ People didn't care about accuracy

Part 3: When God's Word Was Written

4. Who did God instruct to begin writing His words down?

- ☐ Abraham
- ☐ Moses
- ☐ David
- ☐ Isaiah

5. Writing Scripture didn't replace oral teaching—it _____ it.

(Circle one)

Weakened Replaced Strengthened Ended

Part 4: Preserved Through History 6. Match the moment in history with what happened:

- | | |
|---|--------------------------------------|
| ☐ Israel's early history | Scripture recorded and taught |
| ☐ Babylonian exile | Scripture urgently preserved |
| ☐ Time of Jesus | Teaching spoken before being written |
| ☐ Early church | Letters and Gospels written |

Part 5: Making the Connection

7. How does knowing this process affect the way you view the Bible today?

Part 6: Reflection 8. What does this lesson teach you about God's care and faithfulness?

Part 7: Closing Prayer

9. Write a short prayer thanking God for preserving His Word through every generation.

Bonus Question

If you had to explain to someone why the Bible can be trusted, what is one thing you could now say with confidence?

Lesson 3: The Dead Sea Scrolls

Trusting God's Preserved Word



Why the Dead Sea Scrolls Matter More Than You Might Think

Many believers have heard the phrase Dead Sea Scrolls before—but often without fully understanding why they matter. Far from being a piece of Bible trivia, the Dead Sea Scrolls stand as powerful evidence that God has faithfully preserved His Word through history.

This lesson invites you to see how Scripture endured long before modern printing, strengthening confidence in the Bible we read today.

What Are the Dead Sea Scrolls?

The Dead Sea Scrolls are a collection of ancient Jewish writings discovered between 1947 and 1956 in caves near Qumran along the northwest shore of the Dead Sea. These writings include portions of nearly every book of the Old Testament, along with additional Jewish texts and community documents.

Their discovery is considered one of the most important archaeological finds related to the Bible because they give us a direct glimpse into Scripture as it existed more than two thousand years ago.

An Unexpected Discovery

The scrolls were first discovered accidentally by Bedouin shepherds who found ancient jars hidden in caves along the cliffs near Qumran. This unexpected find led to years of archaeological research.

In total, manuscripts were discovered in eleven caves. Many scholars believe the nearby settlement was home to a Jewish sect often associated with the Essenes, a community devoted to preserving Scripture.

Why the Scrolls Matter

The scrolls contain the earliest known copies of Old Testament books. When compared with later manuscripts, scholars found that the wording was nearly identical.

This discovery confirmed that Scripture had been copied and preserved with extraordinary accuracy, reinforcing trust in the Bible's reliability.

Dating and Content

The Dead Sea Scrolls date back to a remarkable period in history—spanning roughly from 250 B.C. to A.D. 70. They were written in Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek, the everyday languages of the biblical world. These were the same languages spoken, read, and understood by the people who lived during the time Scripture was being preserved and passed down.

The scrolls themselves include a wide range of writings. Some contain portions of Old Testament books, offering the earliest known copies of biblical texts. Others include additional Jewish writings that reflect theological reflection and teaching from the period. Still others are community documents, giving us a glimpse into daily life, shared beliefs, and spiritual practices within the group that preserved them.

Taken together, the Dead Sea Scrolls offer a vivid picture of deep faith, disciplined devotion, and careful stewardship of God’s Word—reminding us that Scripture was treasured, protected, and faithfully handed down long before it ever reached our hands.

What This Means for Us Today

The Dead Sea Scrolls remind us that God’s Word has not been lost or altered. Scripture has been carefully preserved through generations.

When we open the Bible today, we are reading the same message God entrusted to His people long ago. The same God who spoke through His Word is the same God who ensured it would endure.

From Preservation to Translation

The Dead Sea Scrolls show us something remarkable: God’s Word was preserved with extraordinary care across centuries. But preservation was never the final goal. As God’s people spread across regions and languages, the Scriptures needed to be understood—not just protected. In the next lesson, we’ll explore how the Bible moved from ancient manuscripts into new languages, making God’s Word accessible to people far beyond its original setting.

****Take a few minutes to reflect on what you’ve read by reviewing the worksheet that follows.**



Worksheet: Lesson 3

Dead Sea Scrolls

1. What are the Dead Sea Scrolls?
2. Where were the Dead Sea Scrolls discovered?
3. Why are the Dead Sea Scrolls important?
4. What time period do the scrolls date from?
5. Name the three major categories of writings found among the scrolls.
6. What languages are represented in the scrolls?
7. Name two major scrolls discovered at Qumran.
8. What do the Dead Sea Scrolls reveal about Judaism during the Second Temple period?
9. How do the scrolls compare with the traditional Hebrew Bible?
10. Who is believed to have written the scrolls?
11. About how many documents and fragments make up the Dead Sea Scrolls collection?
12. How were the scrolls preserved, and where are they located today?
13. List two key takeaways from the study of the Dead Sea Scrolls.

Bonus Resources:

Here are a few YouTube videos to further your study:

Lesson 4: The First Translations

God's Word for All People

How the Bible Traveled Beyond One Language

Most of us open our Bibles and start reading without giving much thought to *how* God's Word arrived in our own language. It feels natural—expected, even. But for most of history, Scripture did not exist in dozens of languages or neatly bound editions.

This lesson invites us to step back and see something remarkable: from the very beginning, God intended His Word to be understood. Not locked away in one culture or language, but shared—crossing borders, tongues, and generations so that many people could hear, read, and know the truth.

The Septuagint: God's Word in Greek

One of the earliest and most influential translations of Scripture is the Septuagint, often called the **LXX**, Translated between **250** and **150 B.C.** in Alexandria, Egypt, it rendered the Hebrew Scriptures into Greek, the common language of the ancient world.

This lesson invites us to step back and see something remarkable: from the very beginning, God intended His Word to be understood. Not locked away in one culture or language, but shared—crossing borders, tongues, and generations so that many people could hear, read, and know the truth.

The Latin Vulgate: Scripture for the Western World

As Christianity spread throughout the Roman Empire, Latin became the common language of the West. Between **A.D. 382** and **405**, Jerome, a priest and scholar, translated the Scriptures into Latin, producing what became known as the Latin Vulgate.

For more than a thousand years, this translation shaped the teaching and worship of the Western Church, making Scripture accessible to countless believers.

Wycliffe's Bible: God's Word in English

In the late fourteenth century, John Wycliffe and his followers translated the Bible from Latin into English. Completed around 1382, this became the first complete Bible available in English.

Though handwritten and controversial, Wycliffe's Bible reflected a growing conviction that God's Word was meant to be read and understood by everyday people.

Why These Translations Matter

These early translations reveal a clear pattern: God continually moves His Word closer to His people. Each translation preserved Scripture while expanding its reach across cultures and languages. Together, they laid the foundation for the many Bible translations we benefit from today.

What This Means for Us Today

Because of faithful translation work throughout history, we can read the Bible in our own language with clarity and confidence. This reminds us that God desires to be known personally and invites us to engage His Word with understanding.

From Translation to Foundation

Through translation, God's Word crossed languages, cultures, and generations, placing Scripture into the hands of people around the world. Yet as we read the Bible today, it's important to understand the foundation upon which all of Scripture is built. In the next lesson, we'll step back to explore the Torah—the first five books of the Bible—and discover how God's instruction laid the groundwork for everything that follows



****Don't forget to take a few moments to reflect on what you just read by reviewing the worksheet on the next page.**

Worksheet: Lesson 4

The First Translations

1. Before this lesson, had you ever thought about how the Bible came to be available in your language?

2. Which early translation stood out to you the most, and why?

3. Why do you think God allowed His Word to be translated into other languages?

(Check all that apply)

- ☐ So people could understand it
- ☐ To reach different cultures
- ☐ To keep Scripture hidden
- ☐ To spread the gospel

4. Match the translation with its description:

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Septuagint | First complete Bible in English |
| ☐ Latin Vulgate | Greek translation of the Old Testament |
| ☐ Wycliffe's Bible | Latin Bible used in the Western Church |

6. Write a short prayer thanking God for making His Word accessible to all people.

Bonus Resources:

Please enjoy the fascinating stories of those who make it possible for us to have the Bible today.

Lesson 5: The Torah

God's Foundation of Instruction

Why the Torah Isn't What Many People Think

When many believers hear the word Law, they instinctively pull back. It can sound heavy, rigid, or even irrelevant—something meant for another time and another people. But the Torah was never meant to feel distant or burdensome.

This lesson invites us to see the Torah the way God intended it—not as a list of impossible rules, but as gracious instruction. The Torah reveals God's heart, His holiness, and His desire to walk in relationship with His people.

What Is the Torah, Really?

The Torah—often called the Law of Moses—is made up of the first five books of the Bible, Genesis to Deuteronomy. But the word Torah doesn't simply mean “law” in the modern sense. It means instruction or teaching.

These books tell one unfolding story: creation, covenant, redemption, and relationship. From the very beginning, God is revealing who He is and how He desires His people to live in communion with Him.

The Five Books That Shape the Story

Each book of the Torah plays a unique role in that story.

—**Genesis** introduces us to creation, humanity, and the beginnings of God's covenant people.

—**Exodus** tells the powerful story of redemption—God delivering His people from bondage.

—**Leviticus** teaches holiness and worship, showing what it means to live near a holy God.

—**Numbers** records Israel's wilderness journey, marked by testing, growth, and God's faithfulness.

—**Deuteronomy** renews the covenant, calling God's people to remember, obey, and love Him wholeheartedly.

Together, these books form the foundation upon which the rest of Scripture is built.

Understanding Covenant: God Reaching Toward His People

At the heart of the Torah is the idea of covenant. A covenant is not a casual agreement—it is a binding promise initiated by God Himself.

In the Torah, God establishes covenants with Noah, Abraham, and Israel through Moses. Each covenant reveals something important about God: His faithfulness, His grace, and His desire for relationship. God does not wait for people to reach Him; He reaches out first.

The Purpose of the Law

So what was the Law meant to do? The Law reveals God's holiness. It defines sin and righteousness. It provides instruction for daily living. And perhaps most importantly, it points forward to the need for redemption.

The Law was never meant to save anyone. Instead, it was meant to guide hearts, expose the seriousness of sin, and prepare God's people to recognize their need for a Savior.

The Torah and Jesus Christ

Jesus never dismissed the Torah—He affirmed it. He lived in perfect obedience to it, fulfilled the sacrificial system, and revealed the heart behind God's instruction.

When Jesus summarized the Law as love for God and love for others, He wasn't replacing the Torah—He was revealing its true purpose. In this way, the Torah ultimately points us to Christ, who fulfills what the Law could never accomplish on its own.

Why the Torah Still Matters Today

Studying the Torah helps us better understand God's character, the seriousness of sin, and the beauty of grace. It deepens our reading of the entire Bible and strengthens our appreciation for salvation in Jesus Christ.

Far from being outdated, the Torah lays the groundwork for everything that follows. It shows us that from the very beginning, God's desire has always been the same—to dwell with His people and guide them in His truth.

From Foundation to Fulfillment

The Torah reminds us that from the very beginning, God revealed Himself through instruction, covenant, and relationship. What started with spoken words, written laws, and carefully preserved scrolls ultimately points us toward a greater fulfillment—God's ongoing work in revealing His truth to His people. As we come to the close of this study, we're invited

to step back and see the Bible not merely as a historical record, but as a living testimony of God's faithfulness, preserved and shared so that His Word might continue to guide, teach, and transform lives today.



****Before moving on, complete the final worksheet in this book as a reflection of what you have read.**

Worksheet: Lesson 5

The Torah

Part 1: First Impressions

1. Before this lesson, how did you usually think about the Torah or the Law?

- ☐ Confusing
- ☐ Heavy or burdensome
- ☐ Irrelevant today
- ☐ God's guidance
- ☐ I wasn't sure

Part 2: Rethinking the Torah

2. The word "Torah" means:

- ☐ Rules
- ☐ Law enforcement
- ☐ Instruction or teaching
- ☐ Punishment

3. How does knowing the meaning of "Torah" change how you view these books?

(Write a sentence or two.)

Part 3: Getting to Know the Five Books

4. Match each book with its focus:

- | | |
|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| ☐ Genesis | Teaching holiness and worship |
| ☐ Exodus | Creation and beginnings |
| ☐ Leviticus | Deliverance from bondage |
| ☐ Numbers | Wilderness journey and testing |
| ☐ Deuteronomy | Covenant renewal and remembrance |

Part 4: Covenant and Relationship

5. A covenant is best described as:

- ☐ A casual agreement between people
- ☐ A binding promise initiated by God
- ☐ A set of optional rules

6. What does God's covenant reveal about His heart toward His people?
(Check all that apply)

- ☐ Faithfulness ☐ Desire for relationship ☐ Grace ☐ Distance

Part 5: The Purpose of the Law

7. The Law was given to:
(Check all that apply)

- ☐ Reveal God's holiness
☐ Define sin and righteousness
☐ Save people from sin
☐ Guide daily living
☐ Point forward to redemption

Part 6: The Torah and Jesus

8. How did Jesus relate to the Torah?

- ☐ He ignored it
☐ He abolished it
☐ He fulfilled it
☐ He revealed its true purpose

Part 7: Personal Reflection

9. What is one new insight you gained about the Torah from this lesson?

10. How might studying the Torah deepen your understanding of Jesus and the gospel?

Part 8: Closing Prayer

11. Write a short prayer thanking God for His instruction, guidance, and grace.

Congratulations!

You've now walked through the remarkable journey of Scripture—from spoken revelation to the Bible we hold today. Along the way, you've seen how God revealed His Word, preserved it with care, and ensured it would be passed faithfully from generation to generation.

More than history, this study reminds us that the Bible is living and intentional—guided by God's hand so that His truth would never be lost, forgotten, or diminished. Understanding how the Bible came to us strengthens our trust in its message and deepens our confidence in the God who gave it.

Congratulations on completing this study and all the accompanying worksheets.

Your willingness to learn, reflect, and engage with God's Word is something to celebrate!



****Before you close this book, take a few moments to enjoy some interesting and surprising facts about the Bible—little reminders of just how extraordinary this book truly is and resource recommendations for further study.**

Just for Fun:

Interesting Facts About the Bible



The Bible is rich not only in spiritual truth, but also in fascinating details. This page is meant to be a light, enjoyable break—offering interesting facts that highlight the depth, history, and uniqueness of Scripture.

- Every minute, fifty Bibles are sold, making it the “world’s best-selling book of all time...every year!”
- In the world, 80,000+ Bible versions are written in 530+ languages. Portions of the Bible are written in around 2,900 languages.
- The shortest verse in the Bible is John 11:35: “Jesus wept.”
- Psalm 119 is the longest chapter in the Bible, while Psalm 117 is the shortest chapter.
- The Gutenberg Bible of 1454 (Latin) was the first book printed on a movable metal type printing press.
- The most popular Bible is the King James Version (KJV), first published in 1611.
- Ancient scribes counted letters and words to ensure Scripture was copied accurately.
- The Dead Sea Scrolls include copies of biblical texts that are over 2,000 years old!
- The Bible begins in a garden (Genesis) and ends in a city (Revelation).
- Despite being written across centuries and cultures, the Bible tells one unified story centered on God’s redemption.
- The Gideons distribute around one million Bibles, free of charge, every week, placing them in hotels, prisons, schools, hospitals, and within the military.
- The most stolen book from merchants is the Bible.
- Archaeological discoveries continue to confirm historical details mentioned in the Bible.
- The Bible has influenced laws, literature, art, music, and culture around the world.

These facts remind us that the Bible is not only sacred but also historically rich and uniquely preserved. Behind every detail stands a faithful God who has ensured His Word would endure through time.



Resource:

Murray, D. L. (2023, May 23). 20 Interesting Facts about the Bible. *BibleReading and Childrens Ministry Canada*. <https://scriptureunion.ca/20-interesting-facts-about-the-bible/>

Appendix: Answer Keys

AnswerKey: Lesson1

Basic Bible Facts

Part 1: Bible Basics Warm-Up

1. The Bible is best described as:

✓ A collection of 66 books written over time

2. The TWO main sections of the Bible:

✓ Old Testament

✓ New Testament

Part 2: What's Inside the Bible?

History – Events & people

Poetry – Songs & prayers

Letters – Instruction to churches

Prophecy – Messages from God

Part 3: Languages of the Bible

- Most of the Old Testament was written in: Hebrew

- Parts of Ezra and Daniel were written in: Aramaic

- The New Testament was written in: Greek

Part 4: How Did We Get the Bible?

1. The Bible was randomly put together. False

2. The Old Testament was carefully preserved by scribes. True

3. The New Testament books were recognized because they were popular. False

4. The word “canon” means measuring rod or standard. True

Part 5: Why Can the Bible Be Trusted?

Correct answers:

✓ Thousands of ancient manuscripts

✓ Fulfilled prophecy

✓ Archaeological discoveries

✓ A unified message centered on Jesus

Incorrect:

✗ Guesswork and legend

Part 6: The Big Story of the Bible

Correct order:

1. Creation

2. Fall

3. Redemption

4. Jesus Christ

5. Salvation

6. Eternal Life

7. Restoration

Center of the story:

✓ Jesus Christ

Answer Key: Lesson 2

Oral Tradition

Part 1: Let's Think Back 1. Answers will vary. Look for growing awareness of how Scripture existed before being written.

Part 2: Spoken Before Written

2. Oral tradition refers to the spoken teaching, repetition, and careful passing down of God's Word within families and communities.

3. Correct answers:

- ✓ People trained their memory carefully
- ✓ Teaching happened within families and communities
- ✓ Sacred teachings were repeated often
- ✓ God designed it that way

Incorrect: ✗ People didn't care about accuracy

Part 3: When God's Word Was Written

4. Correct answer:

- ✓ Moses

5. Correct answer:

- ✓ Strengthened

Part 4: Preserved Through History

6. Correct matches:

- ✓ Israel's early history → Scripture recorded and taught
- ✓ Babylonian exile → Scripture urgently preserved
- ✓ Time of Jesus → Teaching spoken before being written
- ✓ Early church → Letters and Gospels written

Part 5: Making the Connection

7. Answers will vary. Look for increased trust in Scripture and appreciation for God's preservation.

Part 6: Reflection

8. Answers will vary. Look for recognition of God's faithfulness and care.

Part 7: Closing Prayer

9. Prayer responses will vary.

Answer Key: Lesson 3

The Dead Sea Scrolls

Part 1: Answers will vary.

Part 2:

Informational section — no written answers required.

Part 3:

2. Answers will vary.

3. Correct answer:

✓ Hidden in caves near the Dead Sea

Part 4:

Correct answers:

✓ The Old Testament was preserved carefully

✓ Ancient manuscripts closely match later copies

✓ God's Word endured through centuries

Incorrect:

✗ Scripture changed drastically over time

Part 5:

Correct answer:

✓ 250 B.C. – A.D. 70

Part 6:

Answers will vary and should reflect thoughtful engagement.

Bonus Question:

Answers will vary. Look for understanding that Scripture has been faithfully preserved.

Answer Key: Lesson 4

The First Translations

1. Answers will vary. 2. Answers will vary. 3. Correct answers:

✓ So people could understand it

✓ To reach different cultures

✓ To spread the gospel

Incorrect:

✗ To keep Scripture hidden

4. Correct matches:

✓ Septuagint — Greek translation of the Old Testament

✓ Latin Vulgate — Latin Bible used in the Western Church

✓ Wycliffe's Bible — First complete Bible in English

5. Answers will vary. Look for increased appreciation and confidence.

6. Prayer responses will vary.

Answer Key: Lesson 5

The Torah

Part 1: Answers will vary.

Part 2:

2. Correct answer:

✓ Instruction or teaching 3. Answers will vary. Look for reduced fear

or distance and increased appreciation. Part 3:

4. Correct matches:

✓ Genesis — Creation and beginnings

✓ Exodus — Deliverance from bondage

✓ Leviticus — Teaching holiness and worship

✓ Numbers — Wilderness journey and testing

✓ Deuteronomy — Covenant renewal and remembrance Part 4:

5. Correct answer:

✓ A binding promise initiated by God 6. Correct answers:

✓ Faithfulness

✓ Desire for relationship

✓ Grace

Incorrect:

✗ Distance

Part 5:

7. Correct answers:

✓ Reveal God's holiness

✓ Define sin and righteousness

✓ Guide daily living

✓ Point forward to redemption

Incorrect:

✗ Save people from sin

Part 6:

8. Correct answers:

✓ He fulfilled it

✓ He revealed its true purpose

Sources & Further Reading

If you'd like to explore Bible history a little further, these trusted resources are easy to find, beginner-friendly, and widely respected. You don't need to read everything here—think of this as a menu, not a requirement



Online Resources (Free & Easy to Access)

- **Bible Gateway**
Read and compare Bible translations in one place. Great for side-by-side study.
- **British Library – History of the Bible**
Clear articles, images, and timelines tracing how the Bible developed.
- **Israel Museum – Dead Sea Scrolls Digital Library**
High-quality images and explanations of the Dead Sea Scrolls, accessible to non-scholars.
- **Biblical Archaeology Society**
Articles connecting archaeology with biblical history in an understandable way.
- **Blue Letter Bible**
Helpful tools for word studies, timelines, and background information.



Books for Curious Readers (Not Academic)

These books are readable, informative, and well-suited for everyday believers.

- **The Books and the Parchments** – F. F. Bruce
A classic, approachable overview of how the Bible was written, preserved, and transmitted.
- **The Text of the New Testament** – Bruce M. Metzger
Explains manuscript history clearly without assuming prior knowledge.
- **How We Got the Bible** – Neil R. Lightfoot
One of the most reader-friendly introductions to Bible history and transmission.
- **The Journey from Texts to Translations** – Paul D. Wegner
Excellent for understanding how Scripture moved from ancient languages to modern Bibles.

Documentaries & Video Learning

YouTube

 [John Wycliffe – Morning Star of the Reformation](#)

 [Tyndale: The Costly Legacy of Faithful Bible Translation](#)

 [Expert Talk on the Discovery of the Dead Sea Scrolls & Their Meaning](#)

 [Archaeological Perspective on How the Scrolls Were Found](#)

(Many reputable museums, universities, and Christian publishers host free educational content.)



Encouragement

You don't need to master Bible history to benefit from God's Word. These resources are here simply to support your curiosity and confidence as you grow. Read what interests you, skip what doesn't, and always return to Scripture itself.

May God reveal Himself to you as you embark upon this incredible journey.



About the Author

Lesli D. Mize



I discovered my love for writing as a teenager through journaling—a quiet place where I learned to process life, questions, and emotions through words. Over the years, that love grew as I explored many forms of expression, from fiction and nonfiction to poetry and essays. Along the way, I continued to sharpen my skills through practical writing such as marketing materials, business plans, and résumés, never realizing how God was preparing me for something more.

Everything changed when I surrendered my life to Jesus Christ. Writing became more than a passion—it became a calling. What once served personal and professional purposes was transformed into a way to serve others. Through writing, I now desire to encourage, teach, and point every reader to the truth of the gospel and the life-changing love and grace of God.

I am the founder of Balancing the Word Ministry, a ministry devoted to sharing a biblically balanced worldview and helping believers grow in spiritual maturity. My prayer is that through Scripture-centered teaching, readers will be strengthened in their faith and equipped to walk faithfully with Christ, proclaiming Him fully, as expressed in *Colossians 1:28*.



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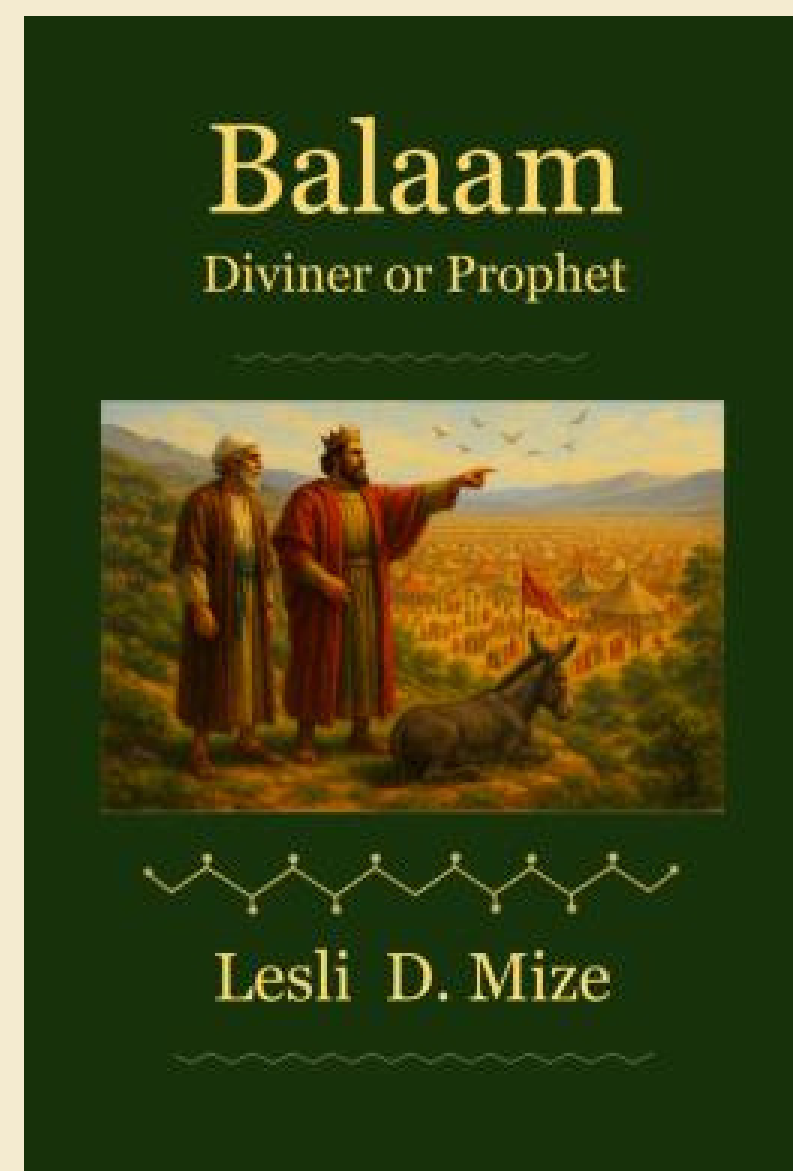
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instagram.com/btwm.2025

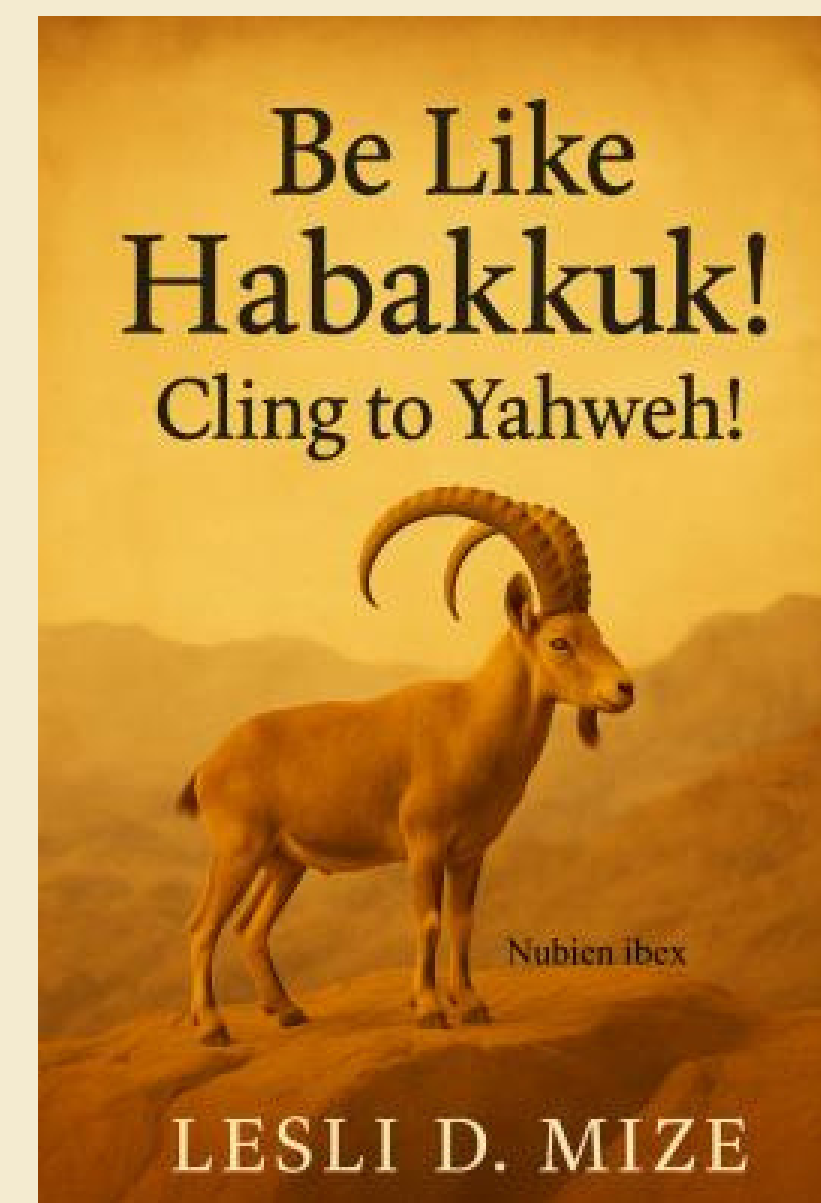
 **Substack**

BalancingTheWord.substack.com

More from the Author



*Balaam:
Diviner or Prophet*



*Be Like Habakkuk!
Cling to Yahweh!*

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The Fast Track to Bible History

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